

Nielsen Norman Group Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

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Product: BoardEase

Task:

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

When a user clicks the "Book Now" or "Confirm" button on the calendar, the app lacks a clear intermediate loading animation or spinner to indicate that the booking request is actively processing.

Recommendations

Add a circular loading indicator or a "Processing Booking..." progress overlay after a user submits a date to show the system's real-time background status.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

Some interface headers or system buttons use slightly generic or technical design jargon instead of local student-friendly terms like "Boarding Houses for Rent", "Dormitories", or "Bedspace".

Recommendations

Revise the text strings and category labels to match the real-world language used by students seeking local accommodations near the campus.

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3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

On the Chat or Inbox page, once a student hits the "Send" arrow button to message a landlord, there is no option to "Undo", edit, or delete a sent message if they make a mistake.

Recommendations

Implement a long-press option on text bubbles allowing users to delete or edit a recently sent message to give them more navigation control.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

The visual styling of back arrow buttons and primary confirmation blocks differs slightly across screens (some screens use a solid background header, while others use a minimal approach), which breaks platform consistency.

Recommendations

Standardize a single header component design and button style to keep the entire BoardEase application looking uniform.

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5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The "Price Range" filter uses an open free-text input box, which can easily cause system errors if a user accidentally types letters instead of numbers.

Recommendations

Restrict the text box to numeric-only inputs or replace it with a range slider component to prevent invalid user data entry.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

Once the filter menu is closed, the selected criteria (like Aircon or Wifi) disappear from the main screen, forcing users to recall their applied settings from memory.

Recommendations

Display active filter chips directly below the search bar so applied parameters remain continuously visible while browsing.

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7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

The "Save List" view provides no direct mechanism (such as a heart icon toggle or delete action button) to quickly remove or unsave an item directly from the list layout. Users are forced to navigate into the specific listing view to undo a saved preference.

Recommendations

Integrate an inline action shortcut, such as a heart toggle or simple close icon, on each card layout within the "Save List" screen to allow instant list management.

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

The "Welcome to BoardEase" banner at the top of the home screen is oversized and occupies too much vertical space. This unnecessarily pushes down the actual boarding house listings, creating irrelevant visual noise.

Recommendations

Scale down the height and typography size of the top welcome banner component to prioritize and give more visibility to the property listings.

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9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

On the date selection screen, if a user attempts to select past dates or unavailable slots, the system block does not provide a clear text-based error message explaining why the selection cannot be confirmed.

Recommendations

Display a clear, plain-language error toast or alert (e.g., "This date is already booked. Please select an available date") to guide the user to recovery.

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

The current Settings screen setup completely lacks any menu link or selection item for a "Help Center", "FAQs", or direct customer support documentation to assist users with booking inquiries.

Recommendations

Integrate a dedicated "Help & FAQs" navigation button component directly onto the Settings layout list to provide instantly accessible documentation for users.